

6, The Chinese People Have Not Realized the Massive Opportunity Costs in Political Decision-Making

During my short internship in the summer vacation, I was required to read the 2023 China Economic Report by CICC (China International Capital Corporation). It was truly a document brimming with absurd gibberish (满纸荒唐). In hindsight, out of their ten predictions for the Chinese economy, nine were completely wrong. Because the arguments within were simply too *"not even wrong,"* I will not waste words on them here; anyone curious can easily find this report.

In late August, my family took a short trip to Yangzhou and Zhenjiang. I had visited Zhenjiang before, but in Yangzhou, I visited the **Grand Canal Museum** (大运河博物馆).

People from free societies might find it incredibly hard to imagine who would ever sing praises for such a project, but that is exactly what happens in China—and the Chinese commoners are completely oblivious to the absurdity of it. Merely to sustain the existence of the absolute monarchy and the bureaucratic system itself, how many lives were extinguished to build this canal? To maintain this canal, the Yellow River was forced to change its course southwards for 500 years, triggering man-made natural disasters that killed countless commoners across the Huang-Huai (Yellow-Huaihe) plains!

It is deeply thought-provoking that a project built upon such immense civilian suffering could be successfully inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage List (联合国教科文组织世界文化遗产名录). This inevitably makes one reflect on exactly what kind of historical values the organization intends to convey to the world when designating cultural heritage.

It was precisely these two things that gave me a deeper understanding of the **"art of language"** (语言艺术) the Chinese rulers use to deceive the commoners.

The brilliant malice of this art lies in: **Only talking about benefits while completely ignoring costs; and if costs must be discussed, implicitly burying all hidden costs—especially opportunity costs.**

If one lives in China long enough, it is very easy to notice these propaganda tactics. The imperial court has always reported only the good news and suppressed the bad. It will only tell the commoners what they have "gained," yet it will absolutely never tell the people how many inherent rights they had to surrender to acquire it.

In fact, through observing Chinese history, I discovered that in political decision-making, **opportunity cost** (机会成本) is likely the most critical factor to consider; its importance even surpasses explicit costs. Yet, within the general cognition of the Chinese people, the very concept that political decisions carry opportunity costs is virtually non-existent!

But it is so glaringly obvious: when you adopt certain decisions, it inevitably renders you unable to execute other decisions. Aligning with certain countries may offend others; co-opting one interest group will plunge you into hostility with another. Not to mention that a state's administrative capacity is finite; human resources, financial resources, and time are never infinite. **"Having your cake and eating it too"** (既要又要) **is fundamentally impossible in politics.**

Although history harbors countless possibilities, only one can ultimately manifest into reality. This is the inescapable reality decision-makers face.

Therefore, I actually believe that the "National Focus Tree" (国策树) mechanism in Paradox Interactive's games like *Hearts of Iron IV* and *Europa Universalis IV* holds definite merit. No matter how much players might mock it, one cannot ignore how simply and clearly this mechanism reflects basic political common sense: **many paths are inherently mutually exclusive**.

The Chinese imperial court is masterfully proficient at deceiving the commoners. The absolute pinnacles of this deception are undoubtedly the **Civil Service Examination** (科举) and the **Grand Canal** (大运河).

The lies surrounding these two have not only successfully brainwashed the commoners living under the Chinese government's rule, but have even hooked a massive number of foreigners!

The so-called Civil Service Examination is, in essence, the ultimate practice of Shang Yang's legalist doctrine aimed at achieving "**All benefits must flow from a single source**" (利出一孔).

The **bureaucratic state** (官僚国家) not only monopolized the distribution of all social wealth, but also, through the imperial examinations, injected an endless, brutal competition for distribution rights into the entire society. It indeed brought temporary stability to the entire empire, **but this stability was achieved at the permanent cost of sacrificing social development**.

Actually, I believe that if anyone were to genuinely and seriously read the examination papers of the top scholars (状元卷) from the palace examinations of the Tang, Song, Yuan, Ming, and Qing dynasties, it would not be hard to realize that these papers are nothing but "shining gold on the outside, rotting cotton on the inside" (金玉其外，败絮其中).

Let alone finding a single genuinely meaningful insight or proposal, just the nauseating sycophancy—such as "*My Emperor, you surpass the Five Emperors and transcend the Three Sovereigns*" (六五帝而四三皇)—is enough to make any reader with an independent personality unable to stomach reading further!

This malicious mechanism—designed entirely to maintain the autocratic **bureaucratic state** by dividing the landlord class, exhausting the intellectuals' mental energy, imposing ideological control and public opinion guidance, and conducting obedience training—is nonetheless presented with overwhelmingly positive imagery in our country's official doctrines, and is even lauded as a symbol of China's "advancement."

And the reason the imperial court manages to pull off such a black-and-white reversal is heavily reliant on its first core propaganda technique: "**The Tactic of Historical Slicing**" (切割术).

That is to say: "*The original intention of this thing was good, but it was just executed poorly after [X person/era].*"

I believe anyone who has lived in China for a long time has heard this propaganda so often that their ears have grown calluses. The truth is, these so-called "originally good" things were inherently imbued with evil intentions from the very first day!

The viewpoint that the imperial examination system of the Tang and Song Dynasties was "advanced and progressive," while that of the Ming and Qing Dynasties was "backward and reactionary," is pure delusion.

As I just mentioned, anyone who takes even a cursory glance at the surviving examination papers across the dynasties could not possibly believe such idiocy. Whether in the density and standard of sycophancy, or in the crimes of acting as the emperor's accomplices (为虎作伥), there is absolutely no evidence that the top scholars' papers from the Tang and Song eras were any less atrocious than those from the Ming and Qing!

The representative of the former is the paper by Wu Shidao (吴师道), the top scholar in the fifth year of the Chuigong era of the Tang Dynasty; the representative of the latter is the infamous "Centralizing Power" (揽权) paper by Wang Shipeng (王十朋), the top scholar in the 27th year of the Shaoxing era of the Southern Song Dynasty.

The introduction of the "Eight-Legged Essay" (八股文 / Baguwen) format during the Ming and Qing Dynasties was nothing more than codifying the sycophantic writing phenomena that already existed in the examinations! **How could anyone possibly argue that the imperial exams did not imprison thought before the Eight-Legged Essay, but suddenly began imprisoning thought after it?**

And the second core technique lies in entirely stripping the commoners of their ability to even *imagine* that alternative historical possibilities exist!

This is the very essence of human domestication orchestrated by the Chinese **bureaucratic state**, far surpassing the machinations of Dr. Goebbels in Nazi Germany.

A demonic architect who masterfully synthesized the arts of human subjugation like Shang Yang (商鞅) would never bother struggling with how to deceive the commoners into believing propaganda. Instead, he struck directly at two fundamental points: **First, entirely destroy the ruled subjects' capacity to think; Second, ensure they remain completely ignorant of everything.**

When human beings no longer possess human intelligence, merely moving according to prescribed protocols like mechanical cogs within the vast **bureaucratic state**, the imperial court's deception can no longer even be called "deception."

It is exactly like the current global obsession with AI. If we intentionally use linguistic traps when conversing with an AI program, and the AI appears to fall for them, can we say we have "deceived" the AI? I am afraid not. Because Artificial Intelligence currently possesses no self-awareness, and how can an entity devoid of self-awareness possibly be "deceived"?

This is precisely where Shang Yang's sinister brilliance lies. When fascist rulers like Goebbels rack their brains trying to deceive the populace and replace truth with fallacy, they have already fallen into an inferior tier of tyranny.

The art of rulership in our country, however, has clearly attained the extraordinary realm of "*the greatest deception resembling absolute truth*" (大诈似信). Since the commoners are both ignorant and utterly incapacitated, whatever the imperial court dictates naturally becomes the "Truth"—because there is absolutely nothing else left that they are capable of comprehending.

This mechanism has achieved spectacular results in the propaganda surrounding the Civil Service Examination (科举). The Chinese people are universally incapable of realizing that the stability brought by the imperial exams was purchased **at the cost of sacrificing the entire nation's future!**

Yes, choosing the imperial examination system might grant a small-to-medium landlord the chance to enter the upper echelons of the bureaucracy.

But do the people still possess the opportunity to acquire massive, intergenerational social wealth through commercial enterprise and seek upward social mobility? Do the people still possess the opportunity to embark on overseas adventures, secure grand achievements, and carve out their own territories? Do the people still possess the opportunity to secure patents through groundbreaking inventions and engrave their names in history? Do the people still possess the opportunity to grapple at the frontiers of scientific theory, driving humanity's understanding of the entire universe forward, and thereby establishing themselves in the world?

We could ask endless questions like this. We can ask about absolutely any divergent outcome between these two worlds in the modern era!

Yes, by choosing the imperial examination system, you indeed acquire highly trained, obedient bureaucrats like Zhang Juzheng (张居正). **But you will never have Yeoman farmers (约曼农); you will never have a Columbus; you will never have a Newton; you will never have an Edison!**

Yes, you can certainly construct immortal engineering marvels like the Grand Canal. **But you will never have a Venice or a Sakai (堺); you will never have the University of Bologna** (*Though one must note that modern universities tend to excessively trace back their histories, and Bologna is clearly no exception. However, because the propaganda of Italian nationalists was so successful, I still use it as an example here*); **you will never have the Amsterdam Stock Exchange; you will never have the candlestick charts (K线图) of Osaka!**

The rulers of the Chinese Empire achieved an astonishing victory here. They tossed the ruled subjects petty favors, yet never let them realize that these petty favors were bought by sacrificing their vastly broader developmental interests!

It is exactly like a house crammed full of people. The emperor barricades the door, seals all the windows, and even blocks the chimneys and the drains, putting everyone inside at risk of suffocation. **Then, you chisel a dog hole in the corner of the wall and shout inside: "Crawl out! I grant you freedom!"**

Consequently, the people inside bash each other's heads in, bleeding profusely over who gets to crawl out of the dog hole first, all while continuously shouting "Long Live the Emperor!" and praising his supreme sagacity and benevolence!

Whether looking at the physiological traits of their cerebral activity, or their social traits as members of a community, the Chinese have gradually ceased to qualify as humans. Instead, they have become indistinguishable from the cormorants (鱼鹰) trained by fishermen in southern China. **Since the dawn of creation, no nation has ever been so utterly tragic.**

The Grand Canal is the exact same kind of example. Even if you completely disregard the lives and deaths of the tens of millions of commoners sacrificed in vain solely for grain transport (漕运)—even looking at it purely from the perspective of historical development: the Chinese constructed the most "outstanding" inland canal in human history, and then what?

Then we lost the oceans that cover seventy percent of the Earth's surface!

Even a nation like Oman could set sail during the Age of Discovery and at least share the stage with global powers. Yet China's rulers harbored deep hostility even towards their own desperate commoners who were forced to seek a living at sea, and sat completely paralyzed as the foreign powers steadily encroached upon them.

Even a pure statist who treats human life like disposable weeds would likely have to think thrice before daring to praise the Grand Canal!

This is also exactly why China so frequently traps itself in the utterly humiliating predicament of **"Winning, winning, winning, until finally losing everything!"** (*This phrase is believed to have originated from a speech by Zeng Shiqiang and later became a ubiquitous meme on the Chinese internet*).

Logically speaking, if a person or a nation truly "wins, wins, and wins" all along the way, it is mathematically and logically impossible to suddenly suffer total annihilation. The reason the Chinese believe they "won their way right into total defeat" is simply because they never actually won in the first place; they were merely scoring psychological victories (精神胜利) exactly like Lu Xun's Ah Q!

However, the problem is that the Chinese behaving like Lu Xun's Ah Q is not intentional. Rather, it is because the Chinese populace has universally lost the cognitive capacity to understand what "winning" and "losing" actually mean.

If we compare political decision-making to an **"optimization problem"** (最优化问题) in mathematics, it is not difficult to see just how pitiable the Chinese are in their understanding of these issues.

The so-called political decision-making process is fundamentally the problem of determining a solution within a **"feasible region"** (可行域).

What kind of feasible region is this? This question is highly complex. It could be the feasible region for the ruler's personal interests; it could be the feasible region for a specific stratum or class; it could be the feasible region for the current regime; or it could be the feasible region for a civilization based on a specific society.

Which feasible region a participant in the decision-making process bases their thinking upon is highly dependent on their standpoint, their environment, and their own ideology.

Therefore, a feasible region can be defined as follows: *For the decision-making entity as a whole, its feasible region is the union (并集) of all choices through which its core concerned interests can still be maintained for a certain period.* The reason the term "feasible" (可行) is adopted is simply that as long as a decision is made within this scope, the core interests focused on by the decision-makers can be sustained. In other words, the feasible region does not immediately become an **empty set** (空集).

The feasible region itself shifts continuously over time. The causes driving its transformation are precisely the objective laws of societal development and the accumulated weight of historical decisions.

For rulers, the solution they select within the feasible region is almost always the **optimal solution** (最优解) tailored for a small, self-centric clique. The more autocratic a country is—and the less its

decisions reflect the broad opinions of the populace—the greater the chasm between the optimal solution for the ruler's small clique and the optimal solution for the overall interests of society!

This chasm constitutes an astronomically massive "opportunity cost" (机会成本).

Because only one decision can be executed at any given moment, if the ruler constantly chooses the optimal solution for their small clique while entirely discarding the overall interests of society, the catastrophic damage inflicted upon the society is glaringly obvious.

Thus, one can easily understand why the Chinese spend all day shouting "win, win, win," only to end up losing absolutely everything. It is nothing more than a corrupted definition of "winning." Autocratic regimes deceive their citizens into believing that *any feasible solution* (可行解) is a "win." But a true "win" is choosing the optimal solution for society as a whole (*which is exceedingly difficult*), or at least a solution that very closely approximates it.

The terrifying nature of opportunity costs in political decision-making lies in the fact that macroscopic human society is a space-time continuum. Policies are executed continuously from their enactment until their actual repeal. **The opportunity costs existing at every single moment continuously integrate and accumulate along the entire timeline.** The ultimate result will be staggering.

For those who do not subscribe to apocalyptic theories, if decisions consistently approximate the optimal solution for the whole society, the feasible region will perpetually exist, and the society will continuously progress forward.

However, if every decision deviates massively from the optimal solution for the whole society, a specific scenario easily arises: **at a certain moment, the feasible region begins to collapse and shrink drastically.**

For the rulers, the ruling clique, or the current regime, the feasible region might ultimately become an **empty set**! In other words, society undergoes a total collapse, and a regime change occurs.

It is exactly at this moment that those clueless, foolish Chinese people suddenly realize they have "won their way right into total defeat." But in reality, they had never won to begin with!

I wish to point out that finding a "feasible solution" for a society is fundamentally not difficult at all. The realm has never lacked talent; no one should improperly belittle themselves.

If one observes every dynasty in Chinese history, it is not hard to discover that at the beginning of these dynasties, the members of their core ruling circles mostly originated from an area no larger than a modern prefecture-level city (地级市).

It is exactly like how some regimes constantly trumpet the massive construction achievements they've made over the past few decades, boasting about their "brilliant leadership" and "correct path." **Yet, they will absolutely never tell the commoners how much change occurred in other countries and regions during that exact same period!** This is deliberately designed to prevent the people from ever realizing the difference between a mere "feasible solution" and the true "optimal solution."

Selecting the **optimal solution** for the entire society is vastly more difficult. It requires the leadership of a sufficiently advanced and powerful class. Sometimes, it also relies on the participation of a few extraordinary heroic figures, and a fair amount of sheer luck is indispensable.

For those **tyrants** (僭主) whose primary business is the preservation of their own privileges, not to mention their lack of will, **these vulgar and shallow-minded creatures** (鄙陋之徒) simply lack the necessary capability even if they desired to do so.

6，中国人民没有意识到政治决策中存在巨大的机会成本

在暑假的短期实习期间，我被要求阅读了中金公司的 2023 年中国经济报告，真可谓是满纸荒唐，对于中国经济的十个预测在事后看来可以说九个都是错的，因为其中的论点实在是过于 **not even wrong**，这里也就不多说，好奇的人想要找到这本书也不难。到了八月下旬一家人前往扬州和镇江进行了短暂的旅游，镇江我之前就去过的，而在扬州我参观了大运河博物馆。人们可能很难想象谁会为这样的工程唱赞歌，但这就是在中国所发生的事情，而中国的老百姓全然意识不到这一点。仅仅是为了维持君主专制和官僚制度本身的存在，这条运河修建的时候死了多少人，为了维护运河而迫使黄河南流的 500 年间又有黄淮地区多少百姓死于人祸所致的天灾？令人深思的是，这样一个建立在巨大平民苦难之上的工程，竟然能够顺利入选联合国教科文组织的世界文化遗产名录。这不禁让人反思，该组织在进行文化遗产认定之时，究竟在向这个世界传达怎样的历史价值观。

正是这两件事让我更加了解了中国统治者欺骗百姓的“语言艺术”，其中妙处在于只谈收益不讲代价，而如果不得不讲成本，一定要忽略隐性成本特别是机会成本。如果一个人在中国长期生活就很容易注意到这些宣传技巧，朝廷是向来报喜不报忧的，它只会对老百姓说你们又得到了什么，却从来不会告诉人民这是用多少本应拥有的权利换来的。事实上，我观察中国的历史发现，在政治决策中机会成本恐怕才是最值得考虑的，其重要性甚至超过了显性成本，而在中国人普遍的认识中几乎就没有政治决策还存在机会成本这个概念。但它又是这么显然，当你采取一些决策的时候就必然无法执行另一些决策，结好一些国家就可能得罪另一些国家，拉拢一个利益团体就会陷入与另一个利益团体的敌对。更不要说国家的行政能力有限，人力，财力和时间都不会无穷无尽，既要又要在政治中是难以存在的。历史虽然有无数种可能性，但是能够成为现实的只有一种，这是决策者所不得不面临的情况。因此我认为 **paradox** 公司的游戏《钢铁雄心 4》和《欧陆风云 4》的国策树机制还是有一定意义，它再被玩家吐槽也好，却无法忽视这个机制如此简单明了地反映了政治中的基本常识，那就是很多路线必然是互斥的。

中国朝廷对于欺骗百姓极为熟练，其中登峰造极之作莫过于科举和大运河，围绕这两者的谎言不但能骗到中国统治下的老百姓，甚至于外国人也有一大堆上钩。所谓科举本质上乃是践行商君法度以最终实现“利出一孔”的目的。官僚国家不但垄断了社会财富的分配，并且通过科举考试将永无止境的分配权竞争引入到整个社会中。它确实给整个帝国带来了暂时的稳定，但是这种稳定是以牺牲社会发展为永久代价的。实际上我认为如果一个人真正认真读过几个唐宋元明清殿试的状元卷就不难认识到这些状元的卷子也不过是金玉其外败絮其中，不要说真正有意义的见解和方案一个也无，光是“六五帝而四三皇”这般令人作呕的马屁话就足以让任何有独立人格的读者看不下去。这般兼有分化地主阶级，消耗知识分子精力，思想控制和舆论引导，服从性训练种种以维护专制官僚国家为目的的如此恶毒的手段，在我国官方学说中却以无比正面的形象出现，甚至于被认为是中国先进的象征。而朝廷之所以能够完成这种颠倒黑白的宣传，第一个核心技术莫过于“切割术”，也就是“某个东西本意是好的，但是从某某某之后就被执行坏了”。我认为这种宣传只要是在中国长期生活的人耳朵都得听出茧子，事实就是这些所谓“最初是好的”的事情一开始往往就带着邪恶的目的。认为唐代和宋代的科举制度是先进的起到进步作用的，明清的科举制度是落后的起到反动作用的，这种观点纯粹是一种臆想。还是刚刚我所说的，但凡看一眼历代科举留存下来的卷子也不会相信这种蠢话，唐宋时期的状元试卷无论是从马屁的含量和水准，还是站在皇帝立场上为虎作伥的罪行都没有证据表明其要逊于明清时期，前者的代表是唐垂拱五年状元吴师道的卷子，后者的代表则是南宋绍兴二十七年状元王十朋的“揽权”卷。明清时期科举的八

股文体，无非是对早已存在的科举行文现象进行规定罢了，怎么可能说无八股时科举就没有禁锢思想，有八股后科举就禁锢人们思想了呢？

而第二个核心技术就在于让老百姓干脆无法想象历史还存在另一种可能，这也就是中国官僚国家驯化人的精华，远远胜于纳粹德国的戈培尔博士。像商鞅这样集人类统治术大成的魔鬼根本就不会纠结于怎么欺骗老百姓使他们相信宣传这种问题，而是会直接从两点入手，一是摧毁被统治者思考的能力，二是让他们什么也不知道。当人已经不具备人的智能，只能像一个机器的零件在整个官僚国家内按照规定程序运动时，朝廷的欺骗就已经称不上骗了。就如同现在 AI 大兴成为全世界的热门话题，如果我们跟一个 AI 程序对话的时候故意使用语言陷阱，AI 看起来也确实上了当，但是难道如此就能说人欺骗了 AI 吗？恐怕是不能的，人工智能现在又没有自我意识，一个没有自我意识的事物如何谈得上被骗呢？商鞅敏锐的地方就在于此，当像戈培尔这样的法西斯统治者想方设法欺骗百姓，让谬论取代真理的时候就已经落入下乘了。而我国的统治艺术已经显然达到了“大诈似信”的非凡境界，既然百姓既无知又无能，那么朝廷的话自然就是真理，因为也没有其他可以被理解的对象。这种手段在对科举的宣传上起到了非常好的效果，中国人普遍无法意识到科举所带来的稳定是以牺牲整个民族的未来为代价。是的，选择科举制度让一个中小地主有机会进入官僚体系的上层，但是人们是否还有通过经营来获得大量可以代际相传的社会财富并且谋求社会地位跃迁的机会呢？但是人们是否还有通过海外冒险博取功名并且坐拥一方疆土的机会呢？但是人们是否还有通过开创性的发明创造获得专利权而名载史册的机会呢？但是人们是否还有在科学理论的前沿搏击以推动人类对于整个世界的认知而以此立于世的机会呢？这类问题我们可以问很多，凡是这两个世界在近代不同的表现，都可以问。是的，选择科举制度你的确能拥有张居正这样训练有素的官僚，但是就不会有约曼农，不会有哥伦布，不会有牛顿，不会有爱迪生；是的，你大可以建造大运河这样的不朽工程，但是就不会有威尼斯和堺，不会有博洛尼亚大学（当然，人们应该注意现在各个大学的校史都有过度追溯的嫌疑，博洛尼亚显然没有例外，但是因为意大利民族主义者的宣传实在过于成功，我在这里仍然将它举为例子），不会有阿姆斯特丹证券交易所，不会有大阪的 K 线图。

中华帝国的统治者在此取得了惊人的胜利，他们给予被统治者小恩小惠，却不令他们知道这些小恩小惠是牺牲了他们更为广泛的发展利益换来的。这就好比有一间装了许多人的房子，皇帝把房子的门堵住，连窗户甚至烟囱下水道都封死，这样房间里的人就有被闷死的危险。这个时候你在墙角开了一个狗洞，对里面说：“爬出来吧，给你自由！”于是里面的人为谁能从，谁先从狗洞里爬出来而打个头破血流，并且纷纷高呼万岁，直称皇帝圣明仁德。中国人无论是从脑活动所具有的生理特征上，还是从作为社群中一员的社会特征上都逐渐不能再被称之为人类，反倒与中国南方渔人训练的鱼鹰相同，自从开天辟地以来，就没有哪个民族这么可悲过。大运河也是一样的例子，就算你抛开为了漕运而白白牺牲掉的数千万百姓的死活不看，即使站在时代发展的角度，中国人修建了一条人类历史上最“杰出”的内陆运河，然后呢？然后我们失去了占地球表面积七成的海洋，连阿曼这样的国家都能够在大发现的年代扬帆远航，与列强至少同台过。而中国的统治者连对于本国被逼无奈出海谋生的百姓都充满敌视，坐看着列强对自己步步紧逼而束手无策。即便是视人命如草芥的纯粹国家主义者，想要称赞大运河的时候怕不是也要三思而后言。

这也是为什么中国常常陷入“赢赢赢，到最后输光光”这般丢人的局面（这句话据信最早出自曾仕强的某次演讲，后来成为中文互联网上的常见语）。按照逻辑，如果一个人一个国家真的一路赢赢赢的话，那就不可能突然间一败涂地。中国人之所以认为自己赢着赢着就输了，无非就是从来也没赢过，只是像阿 Q 一样精神上胜利罢了。然而问题在于，中国人像表现得像鲁迅笔下的阿 Q 一样并不是他们有意为之，而实在是因为中国人已经普遍丧失了对于“输”和“赢”的理解能力。如果我们把政治决策比为数学中的最优化问题，就不难了解中国人在理解这些问题上的可怜之处。所谓政治决策就是在“可行域”中确

定一个解的问题。是什么样的可行域呢？这个问题相当复杂，它可以是统治者个人利益的可行域，可以是对某个特定阶层或阶级来说的可行域，可以是对现政权来说的可行域，可以是对基于特定社会的文明来说的可行域。每一个参与决策的人基于何种可行域进行思考，高度取决于其立场，所处的环境以及自己的思想。因此可行域可以定义为，对于作为整体的决策方而言，决策的可行域就是其所关切的利益仍能在一定时间内得以维持的所有选择之并集。之所以采用了“可行”这样的称呼，无非是决策只要在这个范围内做出那么决策者关注的核心利益仍然可以继续维持，或者说可行域不会立刻变成一个空集。可行域本身随着时间连续地变动着，导致它变化的原因正是社会发展的客观规律以及历史决策的情况。作为统治者来说，它在可行域内往往选取的是以自己为中心的一个小团体的最优解，越是专制的，决策不能反映民众广泛意见的国家，统治者小团体的最优解与社会整体利益的最优解差距就越大，这就是一种极为可观的“机会成本”。因为同一时刻只能进行一种决策，统治者如果每次都选择小团体的最优解而弃社会的整体利益于不顾，那么社会受到巨大损害就是显然的。

所以这样人们就很能理解为什么中国人一天到晚赢赢赢，最后还能输光光，这无非是“赢”的定义出了问题，专制政权会欺骗自己的百姓让他们以为任何一个可行解都是“赢”，但是真正的赢是选择对社会而言的最优解（这是极其困难的）或者起码非常接近最优解。政治决策中机会成本的可怕之处在于，宏观的人类社会在时空上是一个连续体，政策从颁布到实际废止是持续执行的，每时每刻存在的机会成本在整个时间轴上不断累计，最终的结果会十分惊人。对于不相信末日论的人来说，那么如果决策一直接近于对于全社会的最优解，那么可行域就会一直存在，社会也会一直向前发展。但是如果次次决策可行解与全社会的最优解偏差很大，那么就容易出现这么一种情况，到了某个时刻可行域开始急剧缩小。对于统治者或者统治集团或者现政权而言，可行域甚至已经成为空集，换言之，社会经历了一次崩溃，政权发生了更迭。那么到这个时候，那些不明就里的傻乎乎的中国人就会发现自己赢着赢着就输了，但实际上他们原本也从未赢过。我想指出的是，为一个社会寻找可行解根本不是难事，天下从来不缺人才，没有人应当妄自菲薄。如果人们观察中国历史上的每一个王朝，那么也不难发现，这些王朝建立之初其统治核心的成员大多不过出自现今一个地级市大小的范围。就好比一些国家一直宣称过去几十年里取得了多大的建设成就，并自诩为领导有方，道路正确，但是他们却从来不会告诉百姓同时期其他国家和地区发生了多少变化，这就是为了防止人民有一天理解可行解和最优解之间的区别。为整个社会选择最优解困难得多，需要一个足够先进的强有力的阶级领导，有的时候也多亏个别英雄人物的参与，运气也是少不了的。对于那些以保有自己特权为本业的僭主来说，别说他们不想做了，这群鄙陋之徒就是想做也没有足够的本事。